



POLITICS **IN** **NIGERIA**

OLUGBODI EMMANUEL

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Olugbodi Emmanuel

DEDICATION

To all citizens of Nigeria committed to national progress.

PREFACE

Politics in Nigeria! There is no way we can discuss Nigerian politics without mentioning the keyword “Democracy.”

The word democracy comes from the Greek words ‘demos’, meaning people, and ‘kratos’, meaning power. Hence, democracy can be understood as the “power of the people,” a way of governing that depends on the will of the people.

According to Schumpeter (1947), democracy means that the people can accept or reject those who are to govern them. By this, democracy implies conducting elections and choosing leaders who will represent the majority.

Democracy is government by the people. It is a form of government in which supreme power is vested in the people and exercised directly by them or through their elected agents under a free electoral system.

Before democracy in Nigeria, the system of governance was based on military rule. During those periods, absolute power rested solely with the government. The opinion of the people could not dictate government decisions because there was no opportunity to vote or be voted for, and there was no concept of political parties.

However, democracy makes it possible for citizens to be actively involved in choosing their leaders. Hence, people participate in the process of forming a government. They have free will and the right to vote for parties and leaders of their choice. And this right is universal and is not restricted by wealth, social class, or ethnicity.

In a democratic system, different parties present a manifesto or a set of ideas about how a country should be governed. Thus, a democratic government is formed when a majority of people support a particular party as the ruling party.

Undoubtedly, the democratic system of government is a demonstration of political activity. Thus, politics can be described as the activities involved in the making of government or the functioning of government.

Politics is a broad institution comprising different categories of people with varying ideologies. Politics may be bound by certain rules and regulations, yet its deeper activities require intelligence and participation.

So, what can we say about political activity in Nigeria? Everything about these activities (both cunning and unwise) is what will be discussed in this book.

Therefore, this book will focus on four major topics:

- ❖ Political parties
- ❖ Elections
- ❖ Appointments
- ❖ Governance

POLITICAL PARTIES

A political party is a system that brings together people who share similar political ideas to participate in elections, occupy as many political positions as possible, secure representation in the Senate and the House of Representatives, and ultimately aim to produce the President of the country. All these activities are expected to be carried out legally.

Historically, political parties in Nigeria have existed for a long time. The Nigerian National Democratic Party (NNDP) was Nigeria's first political party. It was formed in 1923 by Herbert Macaulay to take advantage of the new Clifford Constitution, which followed the 1914 Nigerian Council. The NNDP successfully organized various Lagos interest groups into a single political entity capable of competing effectively. The NNDP fielded many candidates for seats in the 1922 elections for the Lagos Legislative Council, winning three seats. The party subsequently won all the seats in the elections of 1923, 1928, and 1933.

Although the party's primary function was to place candidates in the legislative council, it also had a broader objective of promoting

democracy in Nigeria and increasing Nigerian participation in social, economic, and educational development. In recent years, competitive political parties have emerged across the country.

Political parties are essential institutions of democracy. They play a crucial role in forming the government by bringing people together to achieve control of political offices, developing policies that serve their interests or those of their supporters, and organising and persuading voters to elect their candidates.

Although political parties are heavily involved in government operations at all levels, they are not the government itself. Traditionally, parties aim to create large memberships to sustain and advance the objectives of their political platforms.

The fundamental purpose of political parties is to nominate candidates who will compete in elections to occupy public office. Other objectives include promoting the interests of their supporters, playing a central role during campaigns and elections, and developing party programmes to guide their activities and policies.

Having discussed the meaning, brief history, and purpose of political parties in Nigeria, we now turn our attention to the structure of these parties.

Sections 221 to 229 of the Constitution of the Federal Republic of Nigeria provide a legal framework for political parties, outlining how they should operate.

These sections make it clear that political parties are the only associations authorised to participate in elections. And the Independent National Electoral Commission (INEC) is responsible for their registration and for ensuring that they comply with regulations.

Importantly, political parties are meant to be inclusive, open to all citizens, and should not be founded on religion, ethnicity, or gender. The Constitution further provides laws to guide and regulate their activities.

In practice, however, political parties in Nigeria have often fallen short of their purpose. Ideally, they should serve as a foundation for national development by producing credible leaders and clear, responsible manifestos. Yet, far too often, they appear to work against progress rather than for it.

For many citizens, the very mention of political parties can evoke frustration or cynicism. Thus, when examining the composition of Nigerian political parties, four main categories of members become evident.

A. Corporate Members

These are the conscientious politicians who enter public service with integrity and a genuine desire to make a positive difference. They are characterised by intelligence, honesty, discipline, and a strong reputation. While some may doubt their existence in Nigeria, they do exist, albeit in very small numbers, often less than five percent of any

party's membership. Unfortunately, the small size of this group limits their influence, making it difficult for them to make substantial changes.

B. Corporate Thugs

This group pursues power at almost any cost, often using cunning, manipulative, or even unlawful methods. Many are educated, yet their primary aim is personal advancement, not public service. During elections, they may sponsor thugs who incite violence and disrupt the democratic process, all while maintaining a façade of respectability. And due to their significant numbers compared to those of corporate members, they often dominate political positions, undermining the efforts of corporate members.

C. Godfathers

Godfatherism is a form of political corruption in which influential individuals handpick candidates who are often less experienced or capable of attaining leadership. These members are usually highly experienced in politics, sometimes having risen through the ranks of corporate thugs themselves. Although they make up a number less than both corporate members and corporate thugs, their influence is outsized. They can determine which candidates succeed, frequently overshadowing the principles of democracy. Ironically, these

godfathers often have reputations that are questionable both within and outside politics.

Godfatherism in Nigerian politics does not end with the use of influence to place someone in a political position. Godfathers often go to extreme lengths to achieve their aims and usually exercise overwhelming control over such candidates. In many cases, this makes them the real individuals occupying those political positions, even though they do not hold office officially.

In some instances, however, the relationship between the godfather and his or her endorsed candidate breaks down. When this occurs, citizens often welcome the fallout, as many illegal and corrupt dealings between both parties are exposed to the public.

D. Political Parties Operatives

The final category of members within political parties consists of individuals I refer to as parties' operatives, otherwise called party militias. This group is made up of people from different backgrounds, but with one common motive: personal interest. They're often utilised during elections, campaigns, and other political activities. And their proportion within political parties is estimated to be above average of the total membership

These individuals can be grouped into two categories. The first category is mainly deployed during primary elections, while the second is more active during general elections.

In most cases, members of the first category are registered members of political parties. Their roles include voting during primary elections, engaging in electoral manipulation, instigating riots or disorder, and participating in other unlawful political activities. These actions are usually motivated by promised rewards such as political appointments or financial benefits.

The second category of parties' operatives are often not formally registered as party members, yet their involvement in politics is significant. During election periods, they actively engage in campaigning, often imposing their political choices on others. They are also involved in spreading political misinformation on social media, vote buying and selling, electoral manipulation and hooliganism during elections. Their rewards are usually monetary, although political appointments are sometimes offered.

The explained groups represent the various categories of individuals that make up political parties in Nigeria. There is no doubt that improvements have been made through increased political education and awareness.

However, the negative effects of the current structure of political parties in Nigeria cannot be ignored. When political parties become avenues for securing employment, accumulating wealth, or making personal investments, serious problems arise.

Poor structural arrangements have produced numerous consequences, and these have consistently posed a threat to national development.

A poor public reputation is one of the consequences of weak political party structures. Regardless of the decisions political parties make or the policies they pursue, many citizens continue to perceive them as associations driven by selfish and unethical interests.

Another effect is the poor selection of electoral manifestos. There is often a very high likelihood of poor decision-making during primary elections. Choosing appropriate and realistic manifestos appears to be a neglected responsibility within many political parties. As a result of these structural weaknesses, many politicians have come to believe that occupying political office is a hereditary right. This explains why individuals who performed poorly in previous administrations often insist on returning to power. And when their ambitions are threatened or frustrated, they frequently resort to unlawful practices to achieve their goals.

Low political standards are another consequence of poor structural arrangements. The standard expected of political parties in Nigeria remains very low, especially when individuals with records of money laundering, age falsification, and other unlawful acts are still considered by political parties as suitable candidates for endorsement in elections.

Another example is the case of individuals who have completed a political tenure and are widely regarded as having performed poorly, yet they're still endorsed by political parties for other positions. In some cases, a political office holder who accomplishes only a fraction of expected responsibilities is celebrated as one of the best leaders the country has ever had.

This trend continues to undermine the integrity of the political system. In a country where the political sector appears more lucrative than productive industries, or where politics is increasingly portrayed as a domain reserved for individuals willing to engage in unlawful political activities, there is a fundamental problem. Nearly every aspect of party politics has become associated with illegality and unethical practices.

There is no doubt that deliberate and effective action must be taken to restructure political parties in Nigeria. Consequently, the concluding section of this chapter focuses on possible solutions to the challenges arising from the activities of political parties.

One proposed solution is the adoption of advanced technological systems to provide comprehensive information on all members of political parties. Such information should go beyond basic details such as name, age, religion, status, and qualifications. It should also include records of career history, achievements, political experience, and, most importantly, criminal records, subject to legal and ethical safeguards.

Furthermore, high moral standards should be enforced across all political parties. Becoming a politician should not place anyone above the law. There should be clearly defined disciplinary measures, including fines, suspension from certain political activities, and, where necessary, outright bans for misconduct.

There is also a need to encourage greater participation of corporate and professional members in political parties. Although many factors discouraging political participation stem from personal, religious, or social considerations, these cannot be ignored. However, continued apathy will only deepen the negative impact on national development.

Meaningful political reform largely depends on citizens' attitudes towards politics. Even individuals who are not contesting for political office can contribute significantly by participating internally in party activities and supporting institutional growth within political parties. Political participation decisions are influenced by relative competence. When aspirants perceive the political environment as populated by similarly unqualified individuals, they are more likely to compete. However, the presence of highly competent opposition would discourage such participation.

Proper organisational structure is another critical area requiring attention. In some cases, political parties possess positive intentions, but poor structural arrangements undermine their effectiveness. There is a clear need for improvement in all political processes, including

screening procedures, electoral processes, conferences, voting systems, and other essential activities.

Finally, political parties should institutionalise structured press conferences for aspirants seeking to become party flag bearers. These conferences should involve unscripted questions on governance, political ideology, motivations for contesting, and policy objectives, to assess competence and preparedness. If such press conferences are consistently adopted, political parties will be better positioned to identify capable candidates. Additionally, this approach would promote merit-based competition and reduce unhealthy practices such as vote buying and godfatherism.